



MEANINGFUL MUSIC

In its simplest form, music has no meaning. However, the addition of lyrics and instruments to some genres of music allows it to communicate a range of ideas and feelings to the listener. This can make music a very powerful and emotive form, which our brains respond to. Some psychologists think that certain areas of our brains have evolved for the purpose of making music, while Canadian-American psychologist Steven Pinker (1954-) suggests that music manages to "tickle the sensitive spots" in parts of the brain that were originally developed for other reasons.

BOTH ENDS OF THE SCALE

Some sounds are widely regarded as conveying certain emotions. For example, a lone violinist has melancholy connotations, while a brass band has happier associations. Our understanding of sounds comes from both personal experience and cultural influences. Generally, in Western music, minor scales create more sorrowful-sounding music, while major scales produce more uplifting pieces. By contrast, in some other cultures, minor notes appear in celebratory music.



BINDING BEATS

Many ancient cultures used music to pass on their history and beliefs to their children. In early hunting civilizations, drums and other percussion instruments were used to send messages from the settlement to hunter-gatherers. On his travels, British naturalist Charles Darwin (1809-1882) noticed how men and women made music to attract the opposite sex, in a similar way to the mating calls of tropical birds. Music has also been used as a means of gathering people together and creating bonds in a community. One example is church bells ringing to draw all of the townspeople to Sunday church service.

MOOD MANIPULATION

In television and radio advertising campaigns, music is carefully chosen to affect the target audience and encourage them to buy a certain product. The latest popular music may be used to appeal to a younger audience, while ambient beats may make tired viewers associate rest and relaxation with the advertised product. Music can motivate as well as manipulate. Marching bands in the military use repetitive drumbeats to ensure that all of the band members keep time and also to unite them in a common purpose.

